

8 Layout tools

Now that we have the basics of styling the core elements of a web page, let's get to a broader perspective, designing the page layouts and the tools needed for it such as floats and positioning. By exploring how they can be applied to basic elements with a core understanding of these key concepts, you'll be armed and ready to face all aspects of CSS layout.

8.1 Floats

The concept of floats is instrumental in designing a layout using CSS. Floats allow you to work against the linear nature of the flow of elements on a normal HTML page. Without floats, each element will get placed below the one above. There would be no columns and no inline images. Before CSS, this problem was overcome to a certain extent by making use of tables in HTML while designing a web page layout.

When you float an element, it becomes a block-level element that can then be shifted to the left or right on the current line. A floated box is laid out according to the normal flow of elements, but it's then taken out of the flow and shifted to the left or right as far as the containing element will allow. Content such as text can flow down the right side of a left-floated box and down the left side of a right-floated box. Floats are needed for placing images between text, creating columns, and making any design with more than one element horizontally.

But understanding floats is really important when you get to using them, because you might find a few pitfalls along the way. Elements following a floated element will wrap around it. If you do not want this to occur, those following elements need to be "cleared," essentially reverting back to the natural flow of page elements. Floats are also required to ensure containing elements do their job and actually contain any floated elements within. Failing to clear those floated elements can result in a container collapsing long before the end of the child elements it contains. Three possible values are available for the float property: 'left', 'right' and 'none'

Gaining a core understanding of floats, is necessary for designing a multi columned layout which is very common these days. Aligning a small image next to a block of corresponding text does not happen normally, you add the image into the HTML and it will always show up only below the text. But when you need a thumbnail image inline with basic introduction text for an article, you have to float the image.